

What else to watch: *Goodfellas* (1990) ■ *Casino* (1995) ■ *Bus 174* (2002) ■ *The Constant Gardener* (2005) ■ *City of Men* (2007) ■ *A Prophet* (2009)



experience of growing to adulthood in the City of God. To achieve this, Meirelles did not bind himself to the narrative constraints of one person's story. The movie does have a central character in Rocket, but he is a photographer, an observer who acts as an audience surrogate, involved but not involved, there to witness the events in the City of God as they occur. The movie clarifies this intention with its use

of voice-over, as Rocket summarizes the favela's defining moments, from the downfall of the Tender Trio in the late 1960s, to the rise of Li'l Zé as a gang leader in the early 1980s. Rocket observes everything as characters flourish and die, as high-rise buildings rise and cartels fall.

The use of voice-over also allows for bolder visual techniques, such as montages that enable a faster passage of time, as well as

Dadinho, or Li'l Dice, (Douglas Silva) is the psychotic kid whose criminal career takes off after he massacres the inhabitants of a motel during a robbery.

the opportunity for more stylistic experimentation. The movie shifts its focus from one central protagonist to another, taking turns telling their stories. It takes up the tales of Shaggy, the leader of the Tender Trio, Benny, the pacifist friend of Li'l Zé, and Knockout Ned, a working man dragged into gang warfare after his family is attacked. With these switching perspectives, Meirelles turns the favela itself »

“A kid? I smoke, I snort. I’ve killed and robbed. I’m a real man.”

Steak-with-fries / City of God